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THURSDAY, OCTOBER 1, 2026

In House, a way around stagnant pay

Many members reimbursed for meals, lodging, raising transparency concerns

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — With their approval ratings in shambles and many constituents struggling financially, members of Congress have been reluctant to give themselves a pay raise. In fact, they haven't done so since 2009.

But with many experiencing their own cost-of-living crunch,

House lawmakers have a recent workaround to boost their wages, which has resulted in an average of 10 percent extra each year on top of their \$174,000 salary.

The workaround is the result of a change in policy by the House in which members can be reimbursed for lodging and meals while in D.C. on congressional business. There is no

such policy in the Senate.

A Globe review of public expense records found that more than 350 House members from both parties have put in for the reimbursements at least once, including half of the Massachusetts delegation. In 2025, House members claimed nearly \$5.5 million for lodging and roughly \$1.2 million for meals, at an average of more than \$18,000 each lawmaker.

Government ethics experts say the program itself isn't necessarily troublesome. But they

called it a symptom of a larger failure of Congress to reform itself.

"It is a Band-Aid because they refuse to make the difficult decision" to raise their pay, said Donald K. Sherman, president of the watchdog group Citizens for Responsibility and Ethics in Washington (CREW), who suggested pairing a raise with other reforms. "It is a deeply uncomfortable topic and politically toxic, but it is a necessary pill to swallow in order to get a

CONGRESS, Page A7

Across Mass., priests sexually abused kids, report finds

1,000 children affected in Fall River, Springfield, and Worcester dioceses

By Anjali Huynh,
Brian MacQuarrie,
and Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

A scathing state report issued Wednesday chronicles a century-long nightmare of child abuse in Catholic parishes throughout Massachusetts, revealing how church leadership systematically concealed decades of predation by scores of priests, who victimized hundreds of children in nearly every corner of the state.

The report concludes an exhaustive, seven-year investigation by the state attorney general's office, which found evidence that more than 270 Catholic clerics abused nearly 1,000 children over several decades in the dioceses of Fall River, Springfield, and Worcester. Church leaders enabled the abuse by shielding predators and concealing allegations, the report found.

Previous probes had revealed similar failures in the Archdiocese of Boston; this investigation, launched in 2019, offers

the most comprehensive accounting yet of how Catholic dioceses in much of the rest of the state failed to protect children by not acting on credible allegations, quietly transferring abusive priests to other parishes, and consistently not reporting allegations to law enforcement.

These institutional failures allowed abuse to proliferate for more than half a century under the leadership of successive bishops, the report says.

In a news conference Wednesday, Attorney General Andrea Campbell called on church leaders to take responsibility, while also advocating for state laws that would make it easier for survivors to take legal action against their perpetrators.

"This investigation was not about demonizing a faith or a church," said Campbell, who also disclosed for the first time that she is a survivor of childhood sexual abuse. "Rather, it was about seeking justice, a val-

CLERGY, Page A10

NO MORE MAGIC FOR SOX



FRANK FRANKLIN II/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Willson Contreras left the field as Yankee Stadium celebrated the 9-2 win over the Red Sox Wednesday night. **C1.**

After another humiliating pounding by the Yankees, it's wait'll next year

September is over and so is Red Sox season. NESN's wildly hyped "Soxtober" playoff coverage never made it to the 10th month.

Boston baseball's 2026 thrill ride came to a sad and sloppy conclusion Wednesday in the Bronx as the Yankees completed a two-game Wild Card Series sweep, 9-2, over the punchless Red Sox.

The '26 Sox were a gift. Chad Tracy's upstarts saved New England's summer the way Scotland saved our World Cup.

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

COMMENTARY

They recovered from a 32-46 start with a record-breaking 32-5 June/July stretch, bringing Fenway to life and creating new interest in a team that features its ancient ballpark as the franchise star.

Unfortunately, the bad Sox re-emerged in September as baseball's worst-hitting team (.219). That malaise

carried into the playoffs, where they scored two runs in 18 innings.

Straight sets, 9-0 and 9-2. An aggregate 18-2. A plus-16 for the Yankees, and a record in the era of the new best-of-three format.

"Disappointing," said Tracy, who's going to get big heat for going to the bullpen too early in back-to-back losses. "The goal is to win the World Series. It's frustrating."

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C5

Flip-flopping

Thursday: Very warm.
High 76-81. Low 64-69.

Friday: More of the same.
High 79-84. Low 57-63.

High tide: 2:56 a.m., 3:08 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:41 Sunset: 6:26

Weather and Comics, D5-6.

VOL. 310, NO. 93

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Suggested retail price
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The lawsuit over an alleged gang rape at Cornell University has sparked fury on campuses — and a recognition that not enough has changed when it comes to addressing campus sexual assault. **B1.**

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth announced some major changes to the military, including cutting 20 percent of generals and admirals. **A5.**

The US said it has completed the withdrawal of all American troops from Iraq, ending a 12-year mission. **A3.**

‘Etsy witches’ no match for Mother Nature

Nor’easter foils wedding spells

By Karyna Cheung
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Couples spend thousands to make sure their weddings go off exactly as planned. A professional photographer to get the photos just right; a hairstylist and makeup artist to make sure everyone looks perfect.

And to help control that most uncontrollable of factors — the weather — brides and

grooms are turning to a higher power: witchcraft.

Last weekend's nor'easter, which blew through some of the fall wedding season's busiest dates, brought a literal coven of spellcasters upon New England, all trying to ward off wedding washouts. Many were hired off the craft and artisan marketplace Etsy, spawning their own profes-

ETSY WITCHES, Page A7

By Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Attorney General Andrea Campbell had just delivered findings from a report on previously undisclosed child sexual abuse perpetrated by the Catholic clergy — adding more horrific stories and disconcerting numbers to one of the darkest, most painful subjects in Massachusetts history.

Then, the state's highest law enforcement official issued one last startling revelation: She, too, is a survivor of childhood sexual abuse.

"For me to stand up here, it would be absolutely inauthentic, and inauthentic to my faith, to not share that I am a survivor of childhood abuse," she said, adding it was "not at the hands of the church, but at the hands of a relative."

While she did not disclose other details, including the identity of her abuser or when it occurred, Campbell said she decided to come forward after her office had for years investigated the clergy and after hearing firsthand the trauma other victims suffered.

"Frankly, my faith has allowed me to overcome that," said Campbell, 44.

The first-term attorney gen-



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

The attorney general said Wednesday that in her case, a relative, not the church, was responsible.

eral disclosed that abuse at a news conference Wednesday addressing an investigation from her office that found nearly 1,000 children had been abused by hundreds of clergy members across three Catholic dioceses.

Producing the 200-plus-page report, she said, was a "very difficult investigation for every team member that was a part of it." Her office reviewed more than 300,000 pages of records and interviewed more than 100 people since 2019, Campbell said, speaking with survivors and their attorneys, clergy members, and experts in child sex abuse, among others.

CAMPBELL, Page A10



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